



UNIVERSITY  
OF ALBERTA

# GPS Minimum Formatting Requirements

Digital, Artistic, Performance-based  
and Mixed-format Theses

Faculty of Graduate & Postdoctoral Studies



With the approval of your supervisor and supervisory committee, you may choose to produce a thesis that is composed partly or entirely of digital, audio, video, or other materials that cannot be presented as text. Be aware that:

- It is your responsibility to ensure that all non-textual elements of your thesis are saved in one of the preferred formats appearing in the Library of Congress' most recent [Recommended Formats Statement](#).
- When you submit your thesis, you will be required to provide a link to all non-textual elements so these files can be downloaded for preservation in the University's Education and Research Archive.
- Theses Canada (part of Library and Archives Canada) prohibits inclusion of personal information in a thesis. Examples include dates of birth, signatures, student numbers, home addresses, and telephone numbers.
- Discipline-specific guidelines in addition to these minimum requirements may be available from your program.
- Although your thesis may primarily consist of non-textual media, it must include a text-based component that constitutes at a minimum a clear description of your thesis.

## General Requirements for the Text-Based Component of the Thesis

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- Every page except the title page must have a page number, in the same place on every page. Use lower-case roman numerals (i, ii, iii, etc.) for items 1-7 the table below and Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3, etc.) for items 8 and 9, if applicable.
- Use a single, conventional font, equivalent in size to Arial 10 pt or Times New Roman 12 pt. Choose a font that is easy to read on a screen, (eg: Georgia 11 pt, Times New Roman 12 pt, Trebuchet MS 10 pt, or Verdana 10 pt).
- Line spacing must be at least one-and-a-half spaces, except for the thesis abstract, which must be double-spaced. Single spacing may be used for long quoted passages and footnotes, if applicable (see "Additional Textual Elements," below).
- Use a consistent, discipline-appropriate style for footnotes, endnotes, or in-text references, if applicable. Check with your program or supervisor for guidance about preferred reference styles in your discipline.
- The text-based description of your thesis must be [saved in PDF/A format](#) for submission to GPS. You will know your thesis has been saved as a PDF/A file if you see a blue line at the top of your thesis title page that reads "This file claims compliance with the PDF/A standard and has been opened read-only to prevent modification."
- You can provide your Open Researcher and Contributor ID (ORCID).

## Consider Adding an ORCID iD

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An ORCID iD (Open Researcher and Contributor ID) is a unique, persistent identifier used to distinguish individual academic researchers. It is issued by [ORCID.org](https://orcid.org) and is widely used across the global research ecosystem.

Purpose of an ORCID iD:

- Prevents confusion between researchers with similar names.
- Remains consistent even if your name, institution, or research area changes
- Links all publications, data sets, peer reviews, grants, and affiliations in one place
- Many universities, publishers, and funding agencies require or strongly encourage having an ORCID iD

- It stays with the academic for life, regardless of where they work.
- What it Looks Like: An ORCID iD is a 16-digit number, like: <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-1825-0097>

## Elements of the Text-Based Component of your Thesis

Follow closely the guidance in the table on page 2 to format the various components of your thesis:

**Green** items are required

**Yellow** items are optional

**Orange** items may be required depending on the characteristics of your thesis

Items must appear in the order indicated

| Item | Component                                | Requirement                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Title page                               | Make sure your title page matches the requirements shown in the Appendix.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 2    | Abstract                                 | A concise summary of your thesis consisting solely of text (no images, tables, etc.) and no more than 700 words. State the subject of your thesis, methods, and general conclusions. Theses written in a language other than English require abstracts in both languages. The abstract always begins on page “ii”.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 3    | Preface                                  | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Provide full bibliographic citations for any material in the thesis that has already been published and indicate the chapter(s) where it appears.</li> <li>• Acknowledge co-authorship or research collaboration that produced any of the material in the thesis and indicate the relative contributions of all collaborators and co-authors.</li> <li>• Provide details of any ethics approval you obtained for the research.</li> <li>• Acknowledge the use of generative Artificial Intelligence/Large Language Models if this has been permitted by your program and supervisory committee.</li> <li>• Acknowledge third-party funding (grants, foreign governments, etc.)</li> </ul> <b>OR</b><br>State that the thesis consists solely of your own unpublished and unfunded work. |
| 4    | Dedications or quotations                | Ask your supervisor or program director if including such material is appropriate in your discipline. One page maximum.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| 5    | Acknowledgments                          | Optional but recommended: and the assistance of your supervisor, committee, and others. 2 pages maximum.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 6    | Table of contents                        | Required only if your thesis includes textual elements saved in PDF/A format in addition to items 1, 2, 3, and 7. Also include every other item in this formatting guide that appears in your thesis, except the title page, in the same order as in the thesis.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 7    | Body of the thesis                       | List items that make up your thesis (websites, sounds/video files, etc.).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 8    | Additional Textual Elements              | Chapters or any other textual portions of your thesis that you wish to submit in PDF/A instead of another format. Begin numbering any such pages with the Arabic numeral 1. <b>All</b> subsequent pages are numbered consecutively.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 9    | Bibliography, Works Cited, or References | Required if no other part of your thesis (e.g. a website) includes a complete list of all sources used in its preparation. Pages should be numbered consecutively, and in sequence with the item 8 above (if applicable).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

See Appendix for sample pages.